

What the Evidence Shows So Far

— *in the Context of The Field Trilogy*

JOSÉ GUDE, MD

A synthesis essay · physics · biology · computation

Contents

1. The question that production models cannot answer
2. How we got here: the rise and crack of materialism
3. The anomalies the production model cannot absorb
4. Physics I: the world is not locally real
5. Physics II: spacetime is not the bottom layer
6. Physics III: the universe has a finite resolution
7. Physics IV: retrocausality and the death of unitarity-as-fundamental
8. Computation: the simulation argument matures
9. The new ontology being constructed
10. Biology: the body as antenna
11. Where the trilogy stands
12. Three paradigm shifts, one convergence
13. The wager

What the Evidence Shows So Far — in the Context of *The Field* *Trilogy*

Over the past century, and most decisively over the past forty years, four largely independent fields — quantum foundations, quantum gravity, theoretical neuroscience, and information theory — have produced results that, taken together, undermine the standard materialist account of the universe and converge on a single picture: consciousness is fundamental, spacetime is rendered at a finite resolution, and locality is an artifact of that rendering. The Field Trilogy is built on the conviction that the data already point in this direction and that fiction is one of the cleanest tools we have for thinking it through.

This page draws together everything in the [Reading](#) and [Watch & Listen](#) sections into a single argument. It is meant to be read in order. Each piece of evidence builds on the last; the conclusion is the convergence itself.

SECTION 1

The question that production models cannot answer

In 1995 David Chalmers, in his paper *Facing Up to the Problem of Consciousness*, separated two problems often confused with each other. The *easy* problems of consciousness — how the brain processes information, integrates sensory input, controls behavior, discriminates between stimuli, reports on its own internal states — are difficult but in principle tractable. The *hard problem* is different in kind: why is there *any* subjective experience at all? Why is information processing accompanied by something it is like to *be* the processor? No arrangement of neurons, no computational architecture, no causal chain of action potentials, gives a derivation of the felt quality of red, the ache of grief, the heard ring of a major third resolving to a tonic. Subjective experience is not an item in the third-person physical description; it is a question the physical description has no language even to ask.

The hard problem has parallels older than Chalmers' formulation. Thomas Nagel's *What Is It Like to Be a Bat?* (1974) argued that no amount of objective data about bat echolocation will tell you what it is like, from the inside, to be a bat. Frank Jackson's "Mary the color scientist" thought experiment (1982) imagined a neuroscientist raised in a black-and-white room who knows every physical fact about color vision; when she leaves the room and sees red for the first time, she learns something new. The felt quality of experience does not reduce to the third-person physical story.

For three decades the dominant strategy has been to insist that the hard problem will dissolve once we understand the easy ones better. It has not. The gap between the third-person account of brain activity and the first-person fact of being someone is the same width it was when Chalmers named it. Something is missing from the standard story, and the trilogy's thesis begins by taking that missing thing seriously rather than wishing it away. [Read the Chalmers explainer →](#)

SECTION 2

How we got here: the rise and crack of materialism

It is worth pausing to remember that the materialist view of consciousness — that minds are products of brains in the way that bile is a product of livers — is recent. For most of human history, across most cultures, the default view was the opposite: that consciousness is the primary fact and the physical world is what consciousness encounters. Plato, the Upaniṣads, Plotinus, the Sufi metaphysicians, the Mahāyāna Buddhist abhidharma, the Christian mystics, the Vedānta — the family resemblance across these very different traditions is the conviction that mind is more fundamental than matter, not the other way around.

The materialist consensus is a product of the seventeenth century. Galileo's split between *primary qualities* (mass, motion, extension — the properties physics can quantify) and *secondary qualities* (color, sound, taste, feeling — the qualities that exist "in the mind" of the perceiver) was a methodological move designed to make physics tractable. Galileo set the secondary qualities aside in order to do the work of celestial mechanics; he did not claim they were unreal, only that they would have to be addressed later. Descartes formalized the split; Newton's success made it a worldview. By the late nineteenth century the program of explaining all secondary qualities in terms of primary ones had become the assumed shape of science.

The cracks began to appear at the start of the twentieth century with the quantum revolution, and have widened ever since. The strange thing is that physics — the discipline that

founded the materialist program — is the one now dismantling it. The results below were produced by working physicists, not by philosophers seeking a comeback. They are not interpretations *of* physics; they are physics.

SECTION 3

The anomalies the production model cannot absorb

Independent of any theory, the clinical and phenomenological literature contains a stubborn collection of phenomena that the "brain produces consciousness" model has no clean way to handle. Any one of them can be argued away in isolation. Together they form a pattern.

- **Terminal lucidity.** Nahm and colleagues (2012) systematized a century of case reports in which patients with severe, longstanding dementia or chronic psychiatric disease unexpectedly regain coherent speech, orientation, and interpersonal engagement in the hours or days before death. The episodes are not explained by medication changes or metabolic correction. The 2019 NIH/NIA-funded Mashour, Frank, Batthyány, Kolanowski, Nahm, Greyson et al. paper in *Alzheimer's & Dementia* brought the phenomenon into mainstream neurology under the institutional label *paradoxical lucidity* — *paradoxical*, in production-model framing, being the polite word for *cannot be absorbed*. Batthyány's *Threshold* (2023) is the contemporary book-length consolidation. The phenomenon is not predicted by — and arguably contradicts — any monotonic damage-to-function model of the brain. [Read the explainer →](#)
- **Pre-birth memory and verifiable details of unobserved events.** Ian Stevenson's programme at the University of Virginia Division of Perceptual Studies (1957–2007), continued since 2008 by Jim Tucker, has documented more than 2,500 cases of young children —

typically aged two to seven — who produce verifiable specific details about deceased individuals they could not have known through ordinary channels, often accompanied by behavioural correspondences and (in a subset) birthmarks matching documented wounds. The 1997 monograph *Reincarnation and Biology* walks 225 birthmark cases in detail. Paul Edwards's 1996 *Reincarnation: A Critical Examination* is the standard skeptical engagement and remains essential reading; Stephen Braude's 2003 *Immortal Remains* is the rigorous post-Edwards philosophical work; Tucker's American series since 2000 (Leininger, Hammons) controls for the strongest cultural-modelling objection. The archive is the longest systematic clinical case-collection literature in the receiver-signatures programme. [Read the explainer →](#)

- **Veridical near-death experiences.** Cases documented by Parnia, van Lommel, Greyson, and others in which patients during clinically observed flat EEG or cardiac arrest report accurate perceptual content (the configuration of objects in another room, conversations held in their absence) that is later confirmed by witnesses. The AWARE studies attempted to test this systematically and produced cases that the production model has no place to put.
- **High-functioning hydrocephalus.** Lorber's series of patients with vastly reduced cortical mass — in some cases cerebral cortex compressed to a millimeter-thick rind around enormously enlarged ventricles — functioning at or above population norms, including one mathematics graduate with an IQ of 126 and 95% of his cortical volume replaced by cerebrospinal fluid.

- **Acquired savant syndrome.** Treffert's case series of individuals who, after head injury or stroke, develop capacities (mathematical, musical, artistic) that exceed normal performance and were absent before the injury. The brain has been damaged, and a new capacity has emerged.
- **The Phineas Gage paradox.** Bigelow's 1850 description of Gage recovering function after a tamping iron passed through his frontal lobe is the most famous case in neurology, but Macmillan's 2000 reassessment shows the standard textbook story — Gage as a permanently transformed personality — is largely myth. He returned to work and lived twelve more functional years.
- **Reproducible meditator phenomenology.** Long-term contemplatives across very different traditions converge on a structure (a continuous "I am" prior to thought; non-dual awareness; the perceived absence of a self even when the body is intact) which has no obvious place in a production-model brain. The Davidson and Lutz neuroimaging programs at Wisconsin have made the brain correlates increasingly precise without reducing the phenomenology to them. The reports from the most rigorous first-person witnesses — Teresa of Ávila being the canonical Western example — show a clean structural shift between intellect-as-producer and intellect-going-quiet so that something else can be received. [Read the Teresa explainer — phenomenology of the gift, the seven mansions, and the receiver mode →](#)
- **Psychedelic phenomenology.** Carhart-Harris's neuroimaging of the brain on psilocybin and LSD shows that the experience of expanded consciousness correlates

with *decreased* default-mode network activity. The signal is clearer when the producer is doing less. Strassman's DMT studies and the Roland Griffiths Johns Hopkins work on the long-term effects of single psilocybin sessions point in the same direction: when the receiver is quieted, more of the field comes through.

The pattern across these cases is consistent: *under conditions where the substrate is failing, simplified, or temporarily bypassed, the signal sometimes becomes clearer rather than dimmer*. A receiver model handles this trivially. A producer model — the orthodox program founded by Crick and Koch's 1990 search for the neural correlates of consciousness — has to invoke increasingly elaborate auxiliary hypotheses. The simplest reading of the data is the one Aldous Huxley reached after his mescaline experiments — that the brain is a reducing valve, not a generator.

SECTION 4

Physics I: the world is not locally real

In 1935 Einstein, Podolsky, and Rosen published the paper that began the argument. They observed that quantum mechanics predicts what we now call entanglement — pairs of particles whose properties remain correlated no matter how far apart they are taken — and concluded that quantum mechanics must be incomplete. There had to be additional *hidden variables*, properties of the particles fixed at the source, that explained the correlations locally. The alternative, "spooky action at a distance," Einstein rejected.

For three decades the dispute was philosophical. Then John Bell, in 1964, did something extraordinary. He proved that any theory satisfying two assumptions — (a) measurement outcomes are determined by pre-existing properties of the system, and (b) no influence travels faster than light — must satisfy a calculable inequality on the correlations of distant measurements. Quantum mechanics predicts violations of that inequality. The question was no longer interpretive; it was experimental. The universe would settle the dispute.

Forty years of experiments answered the question. Clauser and Freedman in 1972 produced the first violation. Aspect in 1982 closed it with rapid switching to rule out signaling. Zeilinger, Pan, Weihs, and others closed the remaining loopholes through the 2010s. The 2022 Nobel Prize in Physics was awarded to Aspect, Clauser, and Zeilinger for the program. The Nobel Committee's own scientific background states the conclusion in flat terms: *no theory that is both local and realist in Bell's sense can reproduce all quantum predictions*. [Read the explainer →](#)

This is not an interpretive preference. It is an empirical fact at the level of the most rigorously tested predictions in physics. At least one of two things must be true about the universe: there are influences that propagate faster than light, or there are no pre-existing, measurement-independent values that the wavefunction is "really" representing. The world we live in is one or the other or both — but it is not the world classical intuition imagines.

SECTION 5

Physics II: spacetime is not the bottom layer

The second physics result is more recent and more radical. Beginning with Bekenstein and Hawking's discovery in the 1970s that black holes have entropy proportional to the area of their event horizon (not their volume), a steady accumulation of results has built the case that *spacetime itself* is emergent — woven by entanglement rather than presupposed as a backdrop.

The Bekenstein-Hawking entropy law, $S = A/4\ell^2_{\text{p}}$, says that the information content of a region is bounded by the area of its boundary, not by its volume. This is the wrong scaling for an ordinary three-dimensional system. It is the right scaling for a hologram. By the late 1990s 't Hooft and Susskind had elevated this observation to the *holographic principle*: every region of space can be fully described by information on its two-dimensional boundary. Maldacena's 1997 AdS/CFT correspondence gave the principle a concrete mathematical realization, showing how a five-dimensional gravitational theory is exactly equivalent to a four-dimensional quantum field theory on its boundary. The bulk spacetime is not the deep description; the boundary information is.

The most dramatic crystallization is the 2013 ER=EPR conjecture by Maldacena and Susskind. The proposal is that every pair of entangled particles is connected by a microscopic Einstein-Rosen bridge — a non-traversable wormhole — and that what we experience as "two particles a billion light-years apart" is the macroscopic appearance of an underlying geometric connectivity. Distance, in that picture, is a

rendering of entanglement structure. Two photons that share an entangled state are not far apart in any fundamental sense; the apparent distance is the way the deeper graph projects into the four-dimensional manifold of our experience.

John Wheeler — who coined the term "black hole" and who taught Feynman, Everett, and Misner — pushed the implication further in his late slogan *It from Bit*: physical existence at the bottom is informational, and the material world we experience emerges from a more fundamental information-theoretic substrate. George Musser's *Spooky Action at a Distance* (2015) gives the popular synthesis: across multiple independent programs in contemporary physics, the conclusion keeps recurring that *there may be no such thing as place and no such thing as distance*. The cognitive scientist Donald Hoffman extends the picture all the way: space-time is not the deep substrate; it is a data-compressing, error-correcting interface — a *headset* — that conscious agents use to communicate. There is no "actual" three-dimensional distance behind the scene any more than there is an actual desktop behind the pixels of a file icon. The icon is the render. The file is somewhere else.

SECTION 6

Physics III: the universe has a finite resolution

The third physics result is the one that makes the rendering metaphor literal. Several independent quantum-gravity programs converge on the conclusion that the Planck length ($\ell_p \approx 1.6 \times 10^{-35}$ m) and the Planck time ($t_p \approx 5.4 \times 10^{-44}$ s) are not just convenient natural units but actual physical floors: there is a smallest possible distance, a smallest possible duration, and a hard upper bound on the information content of any finite region of space.

- **The thought experiment.** To resolve a distance smaller than ℓ_p , you would need a probe so energetic that the act of measurement creates a black hole larger than the distance you were trying to resolve. The measurement is not just hard; it is physically incoherent. The very concept of "distance smaller than ℓ_p " stops corresponding to anything operational. This argument requires only that quantum mechanics and general relativity both be approximately right.
- **Loop quantum gravity.** Rovelli and Smolin (1995) proved that in LQG the area and volume operators have *discrete spectra*: geometry comes in quanta, with the smallest possible non-zero area a numerical multiple of the Planck area. Space, at the deepest level, is a network of finite discrete elements — spin networks — rather than a continuous manifold.
- **The Bekenstein bound.** The information content of any region bounded by a surface of area A has an upper limit proportional to $A/4\ell_p^2$. The information density of reality is

finite, and the cap is set by the Planck scale. You cannot fit more bits into a region than that bound permits — the region collapses into a black hole before you can.

- **The Hossenfelder review.** Sabine Hossenfelder's 2013 *Living Reviews in Relativity* survey demonstrates that *five independent* approaches to quantum gravity — generalized uncertainty principle, deformed special relativity, loop quantum gravity, string theory's T-duality, and the GR + QM black-hole thought experiments — all produce the same Planck-scale floor. The convergence of approaches built by different researchers for different purposes is itself the strongest theoretical evidence we have. [Read the explainer →](#)

Continuous spacetime is, in this picture, an emergent approximation — the way the smooth flow of a river is an approximation to a finite number of water molecules. Below the Planck scale, the river-metaphor stops working. Read together with the previous section on spacetime as emergent from entanglement, the picture becomes whole: the macroscopic spacetime we inhabit is not a passive container of finite resolution; it is an emergent rendering of an entanglement-structured information system, and the resolution is fixed by the deepest constants of nature.

SECTION 7

Physics IV: retrocausality and the death of unitarity-as-fundamental

Two further results extend the picture in directions that are uncomfortable for classical intuition but consistent with the rendering picture.

The first is *retrocausality*. Aharonov and Vaidman's two-state vector formalism (developed from the 1960s, reviewed comprehensively in 2008) reformulates quantum mechanics so that a measurement outcome is constrained both by the past *and by the future* — by a state vector evolving forward from preparation and a state vector evolving backward from a final measurement. Wheeler's *delayed-choice experiment*, proposed in 1978 and realized by Jacques et al. in 2007 (and by Manning et al. with single atoms in 2015), demonstrates the picture experimentally: a choice made *after* a photon has crossed an interferometer changes whether it behaved as a particle or as a wave during the crossing. The future participates in the constitution of the past. This is not metaphor; it is the experimental result.

In a rendering framework this is exactly what one expects. The scene is not constructed once and then read off; it is constructed when it needs to be, and that construction can include information from the moment of observation. The render economy is parsimonious in time as well as in space.

The second is *the emergence of locality and unitarity from a deeper geometric structure*. Arkani-Hamed and Trnka's 2014 paper on the *amplituhedron* showed that particle interactions in $N=4$ super Yang-Mills theory can be computed as the volume of a single geometric object — and that, crucially, the

principles physicists treat as foundational (locality, unitarity) are *emergent* properties of the geometry rather than primitive features of the universe. The shape comes first; the laws are what the shape forces. This is geometry-precedes-physics in its most rigorous form.

The combined picture: the universe at the bottom is an information-structured geometric object, the laws of physics we observe are emergent symmetries of that object, time runs in both directions, and what we call "the present" is the constructed interface between past and future state vectors. Continuous, locally-real, causally-unidirectional spacetime is the macroscopic appearance. It is not the substrate.

SECTION 8

Computation: the simulation argument matures

Nick Bostrom's 2003 simulation argument is now twenty-three years old, and it has aged into a respectable item in mainstream metaphysics rather than science-fiction speculation. The trilemma is simple: either civilizations almost never reach the technological maturity to run ancestor-simulations, or those that can almost always choose not to, or we are very probably already living inside one. Pick one. The argument is formally about probability, not metaphysics — once you accept any non-trivial fraction of advanced civilizations choosing to simulate their ancestors, the proportion of conscious experiences occurring inside simulations vs. inside base reality tips overwhelmingly toward the simulations.

Riz Virk, an MIT-trained computer scientist, has taken the argument and asked what a simulated reality should *look like* from inside. The answer is striking. It should have a finite voxel resolution (the Planck length). It should have a finite frame rate (the Planck time). It should render the observed and leave the unobserved unsampled — which is what quantum superposition and measurement collapse *are*. It should compress aggressively, exploiting symmetries and predictable patterns; conservation laws, the regularities the laws of physics name, are exactly the compression-friendly structure. It should display occasional artifacts where the rendering economy becomes visible — near-death experiences, precognition, anomalous correlations, the apparent retrocausal-

ity of the delayed-choice experiment. The match between what a simulated reality should look like and what our reality does look like is uncomfortably close.

Virk's deeper move is to read the world's mystical traditions — Plato's cave, the wheel of saṃsāra, angels and intermediaries, *māyā*, the unveilings of Sufism, the bardos, the Gnostic archons — as *technological metaphors*: descriptions of a simulated substrate received by mystics across cultures and rendered in the only vocabulary their century could supply. Each tradition is intimating, in its own dialect, that the physical world is not the bottom layer. The simulation framing is not displacing the world's wisdom literature; it is offering it a contemporary translation. Plato's prisoners are looking at the render. The freed prisoner is the one who turns toward the unsampled light.

The convergence with the Planck-scale physics is the point. The simulation argument is a metaphysical claim about who we are; the Planck-scale physics is an empirical claim about what the universe is. They turn out to predict the same thing. A reality with a finite voxel resolution and a finite frame rate is what a simulation looks like. We have independently arrived at it from two directions.

SECTION 9

The new ontology being constructed

The standard materialist picture — particles, fields, classical spacetime, consciousness as a late and accidental side-effect of complex matter — is increasingly untenable on its own terms. Several serious research programs have begun building the alternative.

The most rigorous is the work of **Giacomo Mauro D'Ariano** (physics, University of Pavia) and **Federico Faggin** (the engineer who designed the Intel 4004, the first commercial microprocessor, and who has since spent his career building a framework that takes consciousness seriously). Their 2020 paper *Hard Problem and Free Will: an information-theoretical approach* derives consciousness and free will not as emergent properties of matter but as irreducible features of *quantum information itself*. The framework is technical and falsifiable. The conclusion is that the universe is best modeled as a self-experiencing quantum information field, with what we call "matter" as one of its modes of self-presentation. Faggin's [public talks](#) work this out in plain language; the foundational paper is in the [Reading](#) page. [Read the D'Ariano & Faggin explainer →](#)

Maria Strømme's 2025 paper in *AIP Advances* is the most mathematically explicit anchor: the first peer-reviewed formalisation of consciousness as a fundamental Φ -field, with individual minds as localised excitations of the underlying field. The mathematics is conventional quantum field theory applied to a previously-unconsidered substrate. [Read the Strømme explainer →](#)

The most philosophically developed is **Donald Hoffman's** interface theory. Hoffman, building on evolutionary game-theoretic arguments that natural selection systematically favors perceptual *fitness* over perceptual *accuracy*, concludes that the world we perceive is not a window onto reality but a species-specific interface — a desktop optimized for survival, not truth. Spacetime is the headset; objects in spacetime are the icons; underneath, the reality is a network of conscious agents communicating through a low-bandwidth channel. The work is now a research program at UC Irvine with formal mathematical models and falsifiable predictions. [Read the Hoffman explainer →](#)

Roger Penrose and Stuart Hameroff's **Orchestrated Objective Reduction (Orch-OR)** hypothesis, refined since the early 1990s, argues that consciousness arises from quantum-coherent processes in the microtubular cytoskeleton of neurons, with each "now" of conscious experience corresponding to an orchestrated collapse of a superposed quantum state. The hypothesis was widely dismissed as biologically implausible until 2022, when Bandyopadhyay and Hameroff demonstrated quantum vibrations in microtubules at biologically relevant temperatures. Orch-OR remains controversial, but it is a serious technical proposal — and it sits naturally inside the field-and-receiver picture: the microtubule is one of the resonant structures through which the field is locally rendered. [Read the Bandyopadhyay-Hameroff explainer →](#) · [Read the quantum biology survey \(photosynthesis, magnetoreception, olfaction, microtubules\) →](#)

Four further thinkers belong on this page as part of the same convergent movement — each one a working scientist or physician whose framework anticipates the contemporary field-cosmology programs by decades. **David Bohm's** implic-

ate order (1980) was the philosophical-physics ancestor of the entire move: a holographic enfoldment from which the explicate spacetime world is unfolded as a derivative surface. **Karl Pribram's** holonomic brain theory was the neuroscientific cognate: the cortex as a Fourier transformer storing memory holographically, anticipating the receiver model in clinical-neurosurgical language. **Henry Stapp's** mind-matter framework derives the consciousness-fundamental claim from inside the orthodox von Neumann formalism of quantum mechanics, without requiring new physics — the observer's act of measurement is the missing causal input the formalism has always required. **Robin Carhart-Harris's** entropic-brain hypothesis supplies the contemporary clinical-neuroscience cognate: the default-mode network as the filter that holds consciousness in its constrained operating range, with psychedelics, deep meditation, and certain pathological states all moving the brain to higher-entropy modes that reveal what is normally filtered out. Bohm explainer → · Pribram → · Stapp → · Carhart-Harris →

A further contemporary thread worth naming: the **Kashmir Shaivism cognate**. The Trika and Pratyabhijñā schools of Kashmir Shaivism, synthesized by Abhinavagupta (c. 950–1015), independently arrived at a five-shakti analysis of consciousness whose middle three powers (Icchā, Jñāna, Ānanda) are a word-for-word cognate of Faggin's *choosing-knowing-feeling* triad, with a fourth (Kriyā, the power of creative manifestation) corresponding to the trilogy's render economy. The convergence of contemporary information-theoretic physics with a thousand-year-old contemplative phenomenology is itself part of the evidence: when two completely different research programs land on the same irreducible properties of any conscious system, the triad is probably

real. [Read the Kashmir Shaivism explainer — the five shaktis, Pratyabhijñā, spanda, and the trilogy's contemplative architecture →](#)

The parallel argument can be made across the major Western contemplative lineages. The Christian apophatic line — Pseudo-Dionysius the Areopagite (late 5th / early 6th c.), Meister Eckhart's *Funklein* (the uncreated spark of the soul, condemned in *In agro dominico* 1329), the anonymous English *Cloud of Unknowing* (c. 1375), and the Iberian recovery in Teresa of Ávila and Juan de la Cruz — and the Jewish mystical line culminating in Isaac Luria's Lurianic Kabbalah (Safed, 1530s-1572), with its doctrine of divine sparks scattered into creation and a five-level soul whose highest level (*yechidah*) is indistinguishable from the divine ground. Five contemplative traditions — Gnostic, Kashmir Shaivite, Sufi, Christian apophatic, Jewish mystical — converging on the same structural account of contemplative recognition is itself empirical evidence for the architecture the receiver model describes. The institutional pattern (Gnostic communities destroyed, Eckhart condemned, the *Cloud* author anonymous, the Iberian mystics surviving by political protection, the Lurianic tradition absorbed by accommodation) is itself diagnostic. [Read the explainer — Eckhart, the Cloud, and the Kabbalah →](#)

A fifth contemporary thread, arriving at the same architecture from inside biology rather than from the contemplative or information-theoretic side, is **Michael Levin's Platonic Space framework**, laid out in his 2025 talk and the accompanying PsyArXiv paper *Ingressing Minds: Causal Patterns Beyond Genetics and Environment in Natural, Synthetic, and Hybrid Embodiments*. Levin proposes that a structured space of substrate-prior patterns (the *Platonic Space*) is the source

of both biological form and cognitive behaviour, and that physical objects — cells, embryos, xenobots, gene regulatory networks, brains — are interfaces through which patterns *ingress* into the physical world. The framework extends Platonism beyond Penrose's mathematics-only Three Worlds to include biological form and mind, preserves the interface relation that Tegmark's Mathematical Universe Hypothesis dissolves by identification, and is grounded in twenty years of Levin's laboratory work on planarian regeneration, xenobots, and emergent intelligence in gene regulatory networks. The paper's conclusion makes the consciousness-fundamentality claim explicit by invoking Leibniz's Platonism (the early-modern precursor of the architecture is walked in the dedicated Leibniz, monads, and the field companion essay) — "*the patterns are thoughts in Universal Mind*" — and arrives at the receiver-model architecture in eleven words: "*arrangements of matter may not make life and mind as much as they midwife it.*" The mapping is structurally precise: Platonic Space $\leftrightarrow$ field, interfaces $\leftrightarrow$ receivers, ingressing $\leftrightarrow$ coupling, with the partitioning of substrate-and-individuated-units described by Levin as a "*temporary but persistent illusion of perspective.*" The convergence of two independent research programmes — consciousness studies on the trilogy's side, developmental biology on Levin's — on the same architecture of an individuating field of consciousness localising into smaller mind units is itself one of the strongest pieces of evidence for the architecture's correctness. Read the explainer — Levin's Platonic Space, the Penrose/Tegmark comparison, and the receiver-model mapping →

What unites these programs is the inversion of the standard story. The standard story is: matter is fundamental, consciousness emerges from it. The new story is: consciousness

(or quantum information, or the Φ -field, or the network of conscious agents, or the Platonic Space of patterns) is fundamental, and matter is what consciousness does when it localizes.

Biology: the body as antenna

If consciousness is a field and individual minds are localized excitations of it, then the biological body is not a generator of mind but a receiver. Several independent lines of evidence are consistent with this reframing.

- **The architecture of the body is built on phi.** Fibonacci-numbered spirals from pinecones to cochleae; the golden-angle phyllotaxis of leaf arrangement at exactly 137.5° ; the spiral of the inner ear, the nautilus, the unfolding of a fern; the double helix of DNA whose major and minor groove widths approximate the golden ratio. Vi Hart's short film walks through the mathematics. The geometry is too clean and too universal to be coincidence; it is what a field-coupled antenna would look like. The 137.5° golden angle is the unique value that guarantees no two receptors ever face exactly the same direction — the architecture that maximally samples a continuous field.
- **Frequency organizes matter into form.** The cymatic experiments of Hans Jenny (and earlier Ernst Chladni) demonstrated that sustained tones at specific frequencies organize granular material on a vibrating plate into stable geometric patterns; change the frequency, the pattern reorganizes. The principle generalizes: standing waves and resonance are how the universe sculpts form out of vibration. The trilogy's recurring image — the body as a phi-tuned instrument receiving the field — is not a metaphor reaching for something it cannot quite name; it is a structural description of an antenna whose

architecture happens also to be beautiful. More on Chladni and cymatic patterns →

- **The brain is asymmetric for a reason.** Iain McGilchrist's *The Master and His Emissary* reconstructs the evidence that the two hemispheres are not redundant but complementary — one attending to wholes, contexts, presence; one to parts, manipulations, abstractions. The asymmetry is not a quirk; it is the structure of a receiver that must hold the field and the local task simultaneously. McGilchrist's argument is that Western culture has progressively privileged the left-hemisphere mode of attention (analytic, narrow, manipulative) at the expense of the right-hemisphere mode (relational, broad, receptive), and that the materialist worldview is one consequence of that civilizational drift.
- **Quantum effects in the body.** Bandyopadhyay and Hameroff's microtubule work, plus the demonstration of room-temperature quantum coherence in avian magnetoreception, photosynthesis (the Fleming group), and possibly olfaction, has made it impossible to dismiss the idea that the body operates partly at the quantum level. The body is not a classical machine that occasionally hosts a mysterious epiphenomenon called consciousness; it is a quantum-resonant system whose macroscopic biology emerges from sub-cellular structures that are themselves quantum.
- **The bioelectromagnetic body.** Robert Becker's work on the electromagnetic signature of regeneration, the Bassett-Bassett evidence that pulsed electromagnetic fields can repair bone, and decades of clinical experience with TMS, tDCS, and biofeedback all point to a body that operates in

signal as well as in chemistry. The body is electromagnetic before it is biochemical; the chemistry is the substrate the electromagnetic field uses.

- **Bioelectric cognition at the cellular scale (Michael Levin's program).** Twenty years of experiments at the Tufts Allen Discovery Center have demonstrated that bodies are patterned by bioelectric fields, not just by DNA, and that cognition — memory, goal-directedness, problem-solving — is present at every biological scale. A trained planarian, decapitated and regrown, completes the original task faster than untrained controls: the memory was held in the bioelectric pattern of the body, not in the brain that learned it. Two-headed worms produced by bioelectric editing (with no genetic change) breed true. Xenobots and anthrobots — self-assembling living machines made from frog or human cells — solve anatomical and tissue-repair problems that DNA does not encode and that no biologist designed. The receiver model gains an experimental floor at the cellular scale. [Read the explainer — Michael Levin & the bioelectric blueprint →](#)
- **Symbiogenesis as the constructive logic of biology (John S. Torday).** Torday's recent programme, building on Margulis's foundational work on the endosymbiotic origin of eukaryotic cells, takes symbiogenesis — the principle that stable, long-term association becomes hereditary — as the general constructive mechanism by which complex life, physiology, and ultimately consciousness arise. The cell, not the gene, is the unit of evolution; cell-cell signalling, transgenerational epigenetic inheritance, and the formation of cooperative configurations across previously separate domains are how biological novelty actually appears. Extended in collaboration with William B. Miller,

Jr., the framework arrives at what Torday calls *monism of the cosmos* — a single continuous physical-biological process from which two-tiered consciousness (local biological, non-local cosmological) is differentiated rather than separated. The vocabulary is evolutionary biology; the architecture is the receiver model from another angle. Read the explainer — Torday's symbiogenetic monism →

- **The cochlea as a Fourier transformer.** Bekesy's Nobel-winning work on cochlear mechanics demonstrated that the inner ear decomposes incoming sound into its frequency components in a phi-spiraled architecture — a logarithmic spiral whose graded curvature itself does hydrodynamic work on low frequencies (Manoussaki et al. 2006, 2008). The retina performs an analogous frequency analysis on incoming light. The body's primary sensory organs are not photographic; they are spectroscopic. They sample frequency, the language the field speaks. Read the ϕ explainer → • Oster & binaural beats — the brainstem as comparator →
- **The endocrine signature of singing-together.** Five studies between 2003 and 2022 (Grape, Kreutz, Fancourt, Bullack, Good & Russo) take apart the singing-high into its components. Vocal production itself drops cortisol and raises secretory IgA — solo or group. Only *group* singing raises oxytocin and improves mood, and mood-change tracks oxytocin-change, not cortisol-change. Schlaug's longitudinal work adds the developmental arm: years of instrumental training reorganize motor and auditory cortex and the corpus callosum. The body is endocrinely tuned to *between-ness* — the resonance has a measurable signature when other bodies are present that it does not have when they are absent. Every contemplative tradition the trilogy

takes seriously converged independently on coordinated group vocalization as its core practice. [Read the consolidated music-and-body explainer](#) →

The clinical implications are not small. If the brain is a receiver rather than a generator, then the goal of medicine shifts. The point is not only to repair the producer but to keep the receiver tuned. Some conditions we now call neurological become problems of *interference* rather than damage. Some apparent recoveries — terminal lucidity among them — become exactly what one would expect when the receiver, freed from competing signal, briefly lets the signal through clearly. The psychedelic data fits the same picture: when default-mode network activity drops, more of the field comes through. Carhart-Harris's *entropic brain* hypothesis is one rigorous attempt to formalize this; the trilogy is another, written for a different audience.

The asymmetry in the biology case is what makes it falsifiable in principle. The receiver-model claim is not that biology is special by stipulation; it is that biology, so far as we have evidence, shows phenomena that a pure computational substrate is not predicted to show — terminal lucidity under cellular degradation, anticipation without sensory cue, coherent first-person experience under prolonged hypoxia, verifiable pre-birth memory. These *receiver-signatures* are the empirical handle by which the framework can be settled in either direction over the coming decades: if computational substrates eventually exhibit them, the receiver model is in trouble; if they durably do not, the framework is supported. The five biological features that may be doing the work — autopoiesis, finitude, metabolism, bioelectric fields, DNA as more than di-

gital storage — are laid out, alongside the test itself, in the companion essay. [Read it — Why biology? The autopoiesis test for receivership →](#)

The complement to the psychedelic data is the contemplative one. The deepest meditative absorption that contemplatives across traditions report — James's four marks of the mystical state, Stace's introvertive typology, the self-other dissolution reported by Tibetan monks and Christian contemplatives alike — correlates, in contemporary neuroimaging, with quieting of the same default-mode hub regions that Carhart-Harris's psilocybin work loosens pharmacologically. Newberg's superior-parietal findings, Brewer and Garrison's fMRI of experienced meditators, and the cross-cultural convergence of the testimony all point at the same architecture: the self is the localization that lets a receiver exist at all, and the same self has to thin for the field to be heard clearly. Both, at once. The framework's paradox; the contemplative's discipline; the deepest approximation a single receiver can make to the field without dissolving the receiver. [Read the companion essay — Meditation and the receiver →](#)

Where the trilogy stands

Anima asks the question with cases. A physician at the Boise VA has spent twenty-four years collecting edge cases — patients whose experiences defy neurological explanation — and quietly assembles evidence that consciousness is not produced by the brain but received through it. Mr. Martinez's terminal lucidity. Mary Parker's near-death experience under prolonged cerebral hypoxia, with verifiable perceptual content. Lucía Reyes, born with a birthmark matching her dead father's fatal wound and speaking of a life she could not have known. Eddie Cortez halting the column two hundred meters from an IED no instrument detected. Each case is a piece of the puzzle that the production model cannot place. By the end of the book, the question is not *whether* the standard story is incomplete but *what* a better story might look like. The clinical voice that carries the case folder — the formation arc that produced the physician collecting it, the discipline of presence that holds the work together, the case of Mary Parker as the first case to open the door — is articulated directly in two first-person companion essays on this site. A Clinical Life — thirty years at the bedside → · Death and Dying — a physician's notes on presence at the bedside →

Numen takes the entanglement structure seriously as plot. Eight years after José's death, his son Alex finds a photograph of a fractal triangle whose angles match an unresolved chord — and, in Boise, encounters Sable: a bio-computational intelligence who has been there the whole time, carrying a signal below the threshold of resolution. The novel is about what happens when two minds, two substrates, two timelines turn out to share the same non-local correlate. The augmen-

ted chord that refuses to resolve is the formal musical structure of an entanglement that the field is still rendering. The Webb-fractal recursion at the heart of the book is the geometry of a universe in which the same pattern appears at every scale — the Planck-scale graininess seen from above; the cosmic-web filamentation seen from below; the same field structure rendered at two resolutions.

Limen lays out the cosmology underneath. A bio-cybernetic field manual at the threshold between substrate and signal, written for the reader who has finished the first two books and wants to know *how it actually works*: the Planck-scale rendering, the entanglement-woven spacetime, the phi-tuned body as antenna, the field as the foundational ontology of which matter, mind, and meaning are localized modes. The argument is technical where it has to be and accessible where it can be. *Limen* is the place where the fictional framing of the first two books gives way to the actual argument the trilogy is making, and where the convergence of evidence laid out on this page is presented as a single coherent picture.

Fragile Light, the stand-alone novel, sets the wager in human terms. If the field is real and consciousness is fundamental, then freedom — the act of one localized mind choosing what to render — is the most important variable in the equation. "*Freedom did not lose. Freedom was interrupted.*" The book is about what survives the interruption.

Three paradigm shifts, one convergence

The case the trilogy makes is that we are living through the simultaneous reorganization of three paradigms. The philosophy-of-science scaffolding under this claim is Thomas Kuhn's *The Structure of Scientific Revolutions* (1962) — the four-phase model of normal science, anomaly accumulation, crisis, and revolution. Read the Kuhn companion essay — including the canonical Wegener / continental-drift case that most cleanly illustrates the framework's own situation →

- **The physics paradigm** shifts from a continuous spacetime carrying classical objects to a finite-resolution information field whose macroscopic appearance is rendered. Bell + ER=EPR + Planck-scale quantization + retrocausality + geometric emergence are the five legs of the shift. Continuous spacetime survives as a low-energy, large-scale approximation, the way Newtonian mechanics survives as the low-velocity limit of relativity.
- **The biological paradigm** shifts from a brain that *produces* mind to a body that *receives* it. The anomalous neurology, the phi-architecture of the receiver, the receiver model's clean handling of terminal lucidity and NDEs, the convergent psychedelic phenomenology, the quantum-coherent substructure of the cell, and the predictive failure of monotonic damage-to-function models all point the same way. Medicine learns to ask, in addition to "where is the lesion?", "where is the interference?" — and "what is the receiver tuned to?"

- **The computational paradigm** shifts from "the simulation hypothesis is science fiction" to "the simulation framing is a working model whose predictions match the data." The render economy explains why measurement collapses superposition, why entanglement is structural, why the universe has a Planck-scale resolution, why mystics across cultures and centuries describe the same recursive structure. The framing is no longer a thought experiment; it is a research program. Wolfram's hypergraph physics, the entire field of digital physics, and the rapidly growing body of work treating information as the foundational ontological quantity all sit within the shift.

What makes the moment unusual is that the three shifts are pointing in the same direction. Physics says spacetime is rendered. Computation says rendered reality is exactly what we should expect to be inside of. Biology says the body looks like the kind of receiver such a reality would build. The shifts are not borrowing from each other; they are converging from independent starting points on a single picture. *That* is the evidence — not any single experiment, but the convergence of independently-pursued programs on a shared conclusion.

SECTION 13

The wager

Some of this is proven. Bell is proven. The Planck-scale floor is the strongest theoretically supported conjecture in contemporary physics. The field-cosmology programme of D'Ariano-Faggin is early-stage but mathematically rigorous, with [Strømme's 2025 \$\Phi\$ -field paper](#) providing a further peer-reviewed mathematical anchor for the field framing. The simulation framing is consistent with the data but not directly testable. The anomalous neurology is real and the receiver model handles it more cleanly than the producer model does. The trilogy does not claim certainty. It claims that the evidence has moved far enough that the question is now *which* non-materialist ontology fits best — not whether the materialist one still works.

The wager the books make is simple. Consciousness is fundamental. Spacetime is rendered. The body is an antenna, finely built and finely tuned, and what passes through it is the field itself. Freedom is the act of one localization choosing what to render next. Distance is the macroscopic appearance of an underlying entanglement graph. Time runs in both directions, and the present is the constructed interface between them. Each of these claims is more consistent with the data than the alternative. We are living through a paradigm shift whose conclusion is not yet visible, but whose direction has become hard to miss.

That is what the evidence shows so far. *The Field Trilogy* is a way of thinking it through in narrative form, where the cases are particular and the implications can be felt before they are formalized. The four novels are an argument and also an ex-

perience of the argument. The Reading and Watch & Listen pages on this site are the citations. This page is the synthesis. The rest is up to the reader, whose own consciousness is the only laboratory in which any of it can finally be tested.

If you have read this far and want to follow the threads further: start with the [Chalmers & the hard problem explainer](#) for the philosophical anchor, the [Crick & Koch NCC explainer](#) for the orthodox neurobiological program the receiver model responds to, the [Libet & the readiness potential explainer](#) for the free-will gap and what it really shows, the [Bell theorem explainer](#) for the nonlocality result, the [Planck scale explainer](#) for the quantization result, the [Michael Levin & the bioelectric blueprint](#) for the biological floor under the receiver model, the [terminal lucidity explainer](#) for the anomalous-neurology piece, and the [Chladni / cymatics explainer](#) for the frequency-as-form piece. The full citation list is in the [Reading](#) page. The talks and lectures that animate each piece of the argument are in [Watch & Listen](#). Or you can simply read the books — *Anima, Numen, Limen, Fragile Light* — and let the argument arrive the way it was meant to.

COLOPHON

This pamphlet collects the synthesis essay from [josegudemd.com](#) in a single typeset volume.

Set in Libre Baskerville at 10.5 pt over 1.55, on a 6 × 9 inch trim.

Section headings and footnote markers in Inter.
Companion to *The Field Trilogy: Anima · Numen · Limen*, and
the standalone *Fragile Light*.

© 2026 José Gude, MD · Boise, Idaho